

World celebrations

Throughout the year, in nearly every country or community, people celebrate special events with festivals. Many of these events are religious or have historic links to the farming seasons. Often, a festival is a joyful holiday with music, processions, delicious food and, sometimes, gifts.



FESTIVAL OF THE PIG, FRANCE
One of the funniest festivals is found in the French Pyrenees. People dress as pigs, race piglets, and challenge each other to make the most lifelike pig noises.

TOMATO BATTLE, SPAIN
La Tomatina, as it is called in Spain, takes place at the town of Buñol, near Valencia. Thousands gather for a mock fight with tonnes of squashy tomatoes.



EDINBURGH FESTIVAL
Drama, dance, music, and comedy are just some of the events at this Scottish cultural festival.

AUGUST

In August, it's holiday time for many. Pigs and a very messy tomato fight are among the fun events on offer. There are also arts festivals to enjoy. One of the most important is held in Edinburgh, Scotland.



INDEPENDENCE DAY, USA
Decorated with the American Stars and Stripes flag, a festive cake takes centre table at a 4th July celebration.



BODY-PAINTING FESTIVAL, AUSTRIA
At this event, human bodies are transformed into amazing works of art. The festival includes competitions and displays from around the world.

JULY

Heading the festivals is Independence Day on 4 July. This celebrates the day in 1776 when America declared its independence from Great Britain. In Siena, Italy, a historic horserace takes place. A body-painting festival in Austria is a popular modern event.



PALIO HORSERACE, SIENA
Bareback riders race through the streets of Siena. Each wears colours representing a district of the city.

RAMADAN AND EID AL-FITR
A Moroccan shopkeeper sells trays of pastries baked for Eid. This holiday of sweet treats ends a month of fasting during Ramadan.



SEPTEMBER

Mid-autumn Festival, Moon Festival, Harvest Festival: these are some of the names for feasts all over Southeast Asia at full moon. The celebrations were once held to give thanks for the rice harvest. Harvest celebrations are also an informal part of the Christian calendar.

HARVEST FESTIVAL
Fruit and flowers decorate a Christian church for Harvest Festival.



MOON FESTIVAL, CHINA
Rich pastries known as mooncakes are made for the autumn moon festival in China and other parts of Southeast Asia.



TET TRUNG THU, VIETNAM
Scary masks and dancing in the streets are for children to enjoy in Vietnam's version of the Mid-autumn Festival.

OCTOBER

Homes light up in October. Diwali, the "festival of lights", is a big occasion in the Hindu calendar. The date varies, but often falls in October. On 31 October, things get spooky when grinning pumpkin lanterns appear for Halloween.

DIWALI
Hindu people light their houses with candles and oil lamps to symbolize the triumph of good over evil.



HALLOWEEN
Carving a lantern from a pumpkin is traditional at Halloween. The festival has ancient roots and developed from ceremonies held to honour the dead.



JANUARY

On 1 January, people around the world are eager to party as they welcome in a new year. In Rajasthan, India, it is time for the world-famous annual Camel Festival that takes place in the desert town of Bikaner.



NEW YEAR'S EVE
Firework displays light up cities all over the world as the old year turns into a new one.



BIKANER CAMEL FESTIVAL, INDIA
Wearing a colourfully decorated bridle, a camel waits to perform. Camels are a much-valued part of everyday life in Rajasthan.

FEBRUARY

There is a lot of extravagant dressing up, with two big carnivals this month in Brazil and in Venice, Italy. It's also Chinese New Year, with two weeks of celebrations and family gatherings.



RIO CARNIVAL, BRAZIL
Costume parades, dancing competitions, loud music, and feasting last for five riotous days.